

Startup Idea Generation & Evaluation Worksheet

Idea Name / Working Title:

Date: _____

Phase 1 — Reality Mapping

Goal: Identify areas of friction in real-world systems.

1. Domain Selection

Which domain(s) does this idea relate to?

- ☐ Healthcare ☐ Education ☐ Energy ☐ Manufacturing ☐ Finance
☐ Logistics ☐ Agriculture ☐ Software/Data ☐ Climate
☐ Consumer ☐ Government ☐ Media ☐ Other: _____

Selected domain: _____

2. System / Value Chain

Describe how things work today (steps, actors, flow):

3. Observed Frictions

List inefficiencies you see (cost, delay, waste, errors, bad UX, etc.):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Phase 2 — Insight Discovery (Secrets)

Goal: Find a non-obvious truth.

4. Common Belief

What do most people assume is true here?

5. Contrarian Insight

What might actually be true instead?

“It turns out that _____ because _____.”

6. Evidence / Signals

What observations support this insight?

Insight Statement (final):

Phase 3 — Problem Selection

Goal: Choose a painful, valuable problem.

7. Problem Definition

If the insight is true, what problem exists?

“[User] struggles with _____ because _____.”

8. Problem Scoring (1 = low, 5 = high)

Pain (severity & frequency)	_____
Urgency (need now)	_____
Budget (ability to pay)	_____
Poor alternatives	_____
User awareness	_____
Total Score (out of 25)	_____

9. Target User

Who exactly has this problem?

Role / type: _____

Context / situation: _____

Phase 4 — Solution Design (10x)

Goal: Define a transformative solution.

10. 10x Dimension

Where will you be radically better?

☐ Cost ☐ Speed ☐ Quality ☐ Convenience ☐ Access
☐ Reliability ☐ Personalization ☐ Other: _____

11. First-Principles Solution

Ignore existing solutions. Describe your ideal approach:

12. Solution Statement

“We help _____ achieve _____ by _____,
unlike _____.”

13. Feasibility Check

Is there a plausible path to build this?

Key technologies / enablers:

MVP possible in months? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Unsure

Phase 5 — Market & Business Validation

Goal: Ensure it can become a real company.

14. Beachhead Market (Niche Monopoly)

Smallest group you can dominate:

Who: _____

Use case: _____

Why you can win: _____

15. Market Expansion Path

Initial niche → next → long term:

1. _____ → 2. _____ → 3. _____

16. Business Model

Who pays? _____

What do they pay for? _____

Pricing logic: _____

Recurring? ☐ Yes ☐ No

17. Unit Economics (Rough)

Expected price per customer: _____

Main costs: _____

Gross margin potential: ☐ High ☐ Medium ☐ Low

18. LTV vs CAC Logic

Why will lifetime value be much larger than acquisition cost?

19. Distribution Plan

Primary channel (first 1000 users):

☐ Viral ☐ Direct sales ☐ Partnerships ☐ SEO/Content
☐ Marketplaces ☐ Paid ads ☐ Embedded ☐ Other: _____

Explain:

Phase 6 — 7-Question Filter

Answer briefly but clearly.

1. **Engineering (10x better?):**

2. **Timing (why now?):**

3. **Monopoly (niche dominance?):**

4. **People (right small team?):**

5. **Distribution (clear path?):**

6. **Durability (10–20 years?):**

7. **Secret (unique insight?):**

Overall: ☐ Strong ☐ Medium ☐ Weak

Phase 7 — Moat & Risk

20. Defensibility (check all that apply)

- ☐ Proprietary tech ☐ Data advantage ☐ Network effects ☐ Switching costs
☐ Brand ☐ Scale economies ☐ Regulatory position

Explain strongest moat:

21. Top Failure Risks

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Are they controllable? ☐ Mostly ☐ Some ☐ Hardly

22. Asymmetric Upside Test

If it works, could it be massive? ☐ Yes ☐ No

If it fails, is downside limited? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Explain:

Phase 8 — Reality Testing Plan

23. Key Assumptions to Test

- ☐ Problem is real ☐ Users care enough ☐ Willingness to pay
☐ Solution usage ☐ Acquisition channel works

List top 3 assumptions:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

24. Validation Experiments

What will you run?

☐ Interviews ☐ Landing page ☐ Demo ☐ Prototype ☐ Concierge MVP

Describe:

25. Evidence Collected

Results / learnings:

Decision: ☐ Proceed ☐ Pivot ☐ Kill

Final Decision — Startup Thesis

26. One-Page Summary

Insight:

Problem:

Solution (10x):

User:

Market Path:

Business Model:

Distribution:

Moat:

Why Now:

10-Year Vision:

Final Commitment

Overall score / conviction (1–10): _____

Decision:

☐ Commit fully ☐ Keep exploring ☐ Discard

Notes:

How to Use This Worksheet

1. Use Phases 1–3 to generate many candidate problems.
2. Use Phases 4–6 to narrow to the best ideas.
3. Use Phases 7–8 to test with reality.
4. Repeat until one idea clearly dominates.